Bridging the Soft-Skill Gap in Engineering Hiring, by Onri Jay Benally

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#	Aspect of the Gap	Key Evidence/ Statistic	Implication for Hiring & Retention
1	**Employer demand for soft skills**	89 % of employers in *NACE Job Outlook 2025* rate problem-solving, teamwork, and communication above technical GPA.[4]	ATS screens and job posts still emphasise tools and degrees, missing talent that signals those abilities.
2	**Measured skill shortfall**	Survey of ∼500 firms found new engineers met expectations in just 2/ 26 ABET soft-skill areas—worst gaps: "business perspective" and "verbal communication."[5]	Reinforces perception that "approachable, business-savvy" engineers are rare when the real issue is readiness, not raw potential.
3	**AI era amplifies need**	74 % of Gen Z and 77 % of millennials say soft skills will matter *more* as Gen-AI automates coding tasks.[1]	Demand for hybrid talent will accelerate; hiring rubrics must evolve now to stay competitive.
4	**Executive signal**	Cisco CPO Jeetu Patel calls imagination, empathy, and strategic vision the "grossly underestimated" skills for future engineers.[9]	Top-down messaging legitimises weighting these traits in requisitions and promotion paths.
5	**Candidates must *show*—not list—soft skills**	84 % of managers in a 2024 *Forbes* poll say applicants must *demonstrate* soft skills in interviews.[7]	Behaviour-based scenarios ("explain a trade-off to the CFO") outperform keyword screens.
6	**Closing gaps now a priority**	58 % of companies report that fixing soft-skill gaps is a higher priority post-pandemic.[3]	Yet many still default to technical quizzes; shifting resources to skill-building and assessment is overdue.
7	**Structure slows progress**	Deloitte finds most firms still organise work around static titles rather than demonstrable skills, stalling "skills-based" reforms.[2]	Without new taxonomies, hybrid-skilled engineers remain hidden in applicant pools.
8	**Skills-based hiring exemplars**	Siemens, IBM, and Unilever now credential candidates on strategic thinking and customer empathy alongside coding.[8]	Shows it is feasible at scale and signals to job seekers that breadth is valued.
9	**Early-career rotation programs**	Cisco, Google, Honeywell, and others use cross-functional rotations cited by talent-platform studies as top development pathways.[6]	Rotations boost approachability and business fluency, feeding a stronger internal pipeline.
10	**Mentoring culture reduces turnover**	Mentoring programs cut voluntary turnover by up to 17 % and raise engagement.[10]	Embedding mentoring formalises the soft-skill ethos and keeps well-rounded engineers on staff.

By reframing requisitions around demonstrable soft skills, using behaviour-anchored interviews, and institutionalising rotations and mentoring, companies unlock a talent pool that is both technically excellent ***and*** *business-savvy—bridging a gap created less by scarcity and more by legacy hiring filters.*

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